

LING 201 Midterm Review

⚠ Questions on this handout might not be exactly what will appear on the final. ⚠

⚠ Please look at past slides and exercises for review as well. ⚠

1. Introduction to Linguistics

- **Linguistics** is the *scientific* study of language.
- Linguists use the scientific method to uncover the *competence* or knowledge of language users.
- While there are both prescriptive and descriptive rules relating to language, linguists are interested in uncovering the *descriptive rules* of a language.
 - **Descriptive Rules:** Rules that describe how people use their language. These rules are often learned and used tacitly.
 - **Prescriptive Rules:** Rules that tell people how they should speak (or write). Usually require some effort to learn. Are often broken.
- Often times the descriptive rules are *tacit*, hence speakers are not aware that they are following them.
- We can use the scientific method to uncover rules of languages we ourselves speak or languages we are unfamiliar with.

2. Morphology

- **Morpheme** is the *smallest* linguistic unit that carries meaning or grammatical function.
- **Complex** word: Word which contains more than one morpheme.
- **Simple** word: Word which consists of a single morpheme.
- **Free** morphemes can stand alone as a word. e.g. *dog, cat, house, . . .*
- **Bound** morphemes cannot stand alone. e.g. *-er, -s, cran-, . . .*
 - Affixes: prefixes, suffixes, infixes, circumfixes
 - Bound roots: *cran-, rasp-*
- **Root:** the ‘base’ morpheme to which affixes attach. These contribute the ‘basic’ meaning.
- **Derivational** morphemes change meaning, creating new words.
 - Often, but not always, they also change the part of speech.
 - *clever-ness, enjoy-ment, lion-ess, deriv-ation-al*
- **Inflectional** morphemes provide grammatical information, and indicate ‘agreement’ or ‘conjugation’ in some contexts.
 - They do not change part of speech of the base.
 - Tense (*-ed*), aspect (*-ing*), number (*-s*), person (*-s*), noun class, case

- Morpheme boundaries *do not necessarily correspond* with other linguistics divisions like syllable boundaries.
 - A single morpheme in one language can be translated into more than one morpheme (or even multiple words) in another language.
 - Just because a morpheme corresponds to a word in English does not mean it is necessarily a word in the given language.
- **Foreign morphemic analysis** - Swahili (from Assignment 1)

The general procedure for handling morphemic analysis problems:

- 1) First, break down the English translations into morphemes.
 e.g., 'I see them' = I + present tense + see + them.
 'You will see me' = you + will + see + me.
 'I saw you' = I + past + see + you.
- 2) Then find two translations that are either:
 - the exact same except for one morpheme that's different – for example, 'I speak' and 'you speak'. OR
 - completely different except for one morpheme that's the same – for example, 'she speaks' and 'she sees me'.
- 3) Finally, compare the English translation and the foreign word.
 - If you found two translations that are the same except for one morpheme, then whatever is different between the foreign words = the one morpheme that's different between the translations.
 - If you found two translations that are completely different except for one morpheme, then what is the same between the foreign words = the one morpheme that's the same between the translations.
 - Note that the order of morpheme in that language may be different from that in English.

Exercise #1: Revisiting Swahili

Consider the following examples from Swahili of Eastern Congo and answer the questions below.

- | | | | | | |
|------|-----------|---------------|-------|--------------|--------------------|
| i. | Ninasema. | ‘I speak.’ | vi. | Niliona. | ‘I saw.’ |
| ii. | Wunasema. | ‘You speak.’ | vii. | Ninawaona. | ‘I see them.’ |
| iii. | Anasema. | ‘She speaks.’ | viii. | Niliwuona. | ‘I saw you.’ |
| iv. | Wanasema. | ‘They speak.’ | ix. | Ananiona. | ‘She sees me.’ |
| v. | Ninaona. | ‘I see.’ | x. | Wutakaniona. | ‘You will see me.’ |

- (1) Try to match the meanings below with a morpheme in the Swahili data. Hints: The morphemes for subject and object pronouns are the same (e.g., the morpheme for ‘I’ is the same as the morpheme for ‘me’).

speak	_____	I/me	_____
see	_____	they/them	_____
present	_____	you	_____
past	_____	will	_____

3. Syntax

3.1. Parts of speech/syntactic categories

- Noun (N):
 - can combine with plural morpheme *-s*;
 - often ends with *-ion/-ment/...*;
 - can occur after a determiner, ...
- Verb (V):
 - can combine with past morpheme *-d*, has combined with *-ize*, ...
 - can follow an auxiliary (*does*), modal (*might*), or negation (*not*), ...
- Adjective (Adj):
 - can combine with *un-*, has combined with *-able*, ...
 - can occur between a determiner and a noun, ...
- Adverb (Adv):
 - appear with *-ly*, ...
 - can’t appear between a determiner and a noun, ...

3.2. Open vs. closed parts of speech

- **Open:** N, V, Adj, Adv
- **Closed:** D, P, Conj, C, T, Neg, ...

3.3. Lexical vs. functional parts of speech

- **Lexical** parts of speech (N, V, Adj, Adv) provide the *content* of the sentence.
- **Functional** parts of speech (D, P, Conj, C, T, Neg) provide the *grammatical* information.

3.4. Examples of some syntactic categories

- Determiner (D): *a/an, the, every, some, no, most, ...*
- Preposition (P): *over, under, in, near, on, to, with, of, . . .*
- Conjunction (Conj): *and, or, neither-nor, either-or, . . .*
- Complementizers (C): *that, whether, if, . . .*
- Tense (T):
 - Auxiliary: *has/have/had, am/is/are/was/were, do/does/did*
 - Modals: *will, would, shall, should, can, could, may, might, must*
 - Non-finite tense marker: *to*
- Negation (Neg): *not*

3.5. Constituency tests

- A group of words that function as a unit is called a **constituent**.
- Constituency test applies to a portion of a sentence and identify whether groups of words act together as a unit or not.
- If the constituency test doesn't apply, we can do the same way but using * (ungrammatical) notation to show that the test doesn't work.
- The important point is that when applying these tests to a group of words, the sentence *still needs to make sense*.

- 1) **Replacement** test: If a string of words can be replaced with by a pronoun (*he/she/they*), an adverb (*here/there*) or a do verb (*did/did so*), then that string of words is a constituent.

Example:

- The students from New Brunswick stopped by. → They stopped by.
- Mary went to school. → Mary went there.
- Mary went to school. → Mary did so.

2) **Fragment** test: If a string of words can serve as the answer to some *wh*-question, then it is a constituent.

○ Example:

Q: Who stopped by?

A: The students from New Brunswick.

3) **Movement** tests: If a string of words can be moved, then it is a constituent.

i. Topicalization:

Example: I saw **a sheep**. → **A sheep**, I saw.

ii. Passivation:

Example: I saw **a sheep**. → **A sheep** was seen by me.

iii. Clefting:

Example: I saw **a sheep**. → It was **a sheep** that I saw.

iv. Pseudo-clefting: (or pre-posing)

Example: I saw **a sheep**. → A sheep was what I saw.

Exercise #3: Constituency test

The students loved their syntax assignment.

- Is this a constituent?
- Replacement test:
- Fragment test:
- Movement test:

The students loved their syntax assignment.

- Is this a constituent?
- Replacement test:
- Fragment test:
- Movement test:

3.6. Phrase structure rules

CP → (C) TP TP → {NP, CP} T VP NP → (D) (AdjP+) N (PP+) (CP) PP → P NP AdjP → (AdvP) Adj AdvP → (AdvP) Adv VP → (AdvP+) V (NP) ({NP, CP}) (AdvP+) (PP+) (AdvP+)
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⚠ **Tips for drawing trees:** ⚠

1. Every sentence is a TP, which means you should have a TP node as the top-most node, **even if there is no visible T**.
 - T can be overt as ‘*will*’, or it can also be covert when the tense of the sentence is past tense.
2. Be careful whether a PP is grouped under an NP or a VP (think about the meaning of the sentence to help decide).
3. When you have an Adj, make sure it is first connected to an AdjP node before you connect it to anything else.

In other words, you should have:

AdjP
|
Adj
Smart

And you should not have only:

AdjP
|
Smart

You also should not have only:

Adj
Smart

Exercise #4: Structural ambiguity

<i>A cat with a bow from Berlin</i>
Interpretation 1: _____
Syntactic tree:
Interpretation 2: _____

Syntactic tree:

Mary saw a person with a telescope.

Interpretation 1: _____

Syntactic tree:

Interpretation 2: _____

Syntactic tree: